

2010: The year of the OSes

While 2010 has been the year of the tablet, we certainly think it might as well be called the year of the mobile. We saw the launch of new mobile operating systems, countless phones, new chipsets, new display technologies, tablet-phones, phone-cameras, and a lot more...

New OSes

Seven new operating systems were released in 2010 – Apple's much updated iOS 4, Google's polished Android Froyo, RIM's touch-friendly BlackBerry OS 6, Symbian Foundation's much maligned Symbian^3, Intel and Nokia's MeeGo, HP-Palm's refreshed webOS2.0, and Microsoft's mixed review champion – Windows Phone 7.

All of these brought something new to the table, and all of them learnt something from each other. A thing that they all share in common is a conscious movement towards simplicity, with seamless form, followed-up by powerful functionality. Each offered users many of the features they'd been asking for, and each received varied amounts of praise and criticism. No matter how well they fared against each other now,

the future of all these platforms looks promising, with major updates already promised to arrive by next year, and all the bustling competition making the end user the real winner.

Apple's iOS devices, and the iPhone have been doing especially well this year – over 14 million iPhones sold in last quarter. However, Android saw the most remarkable growth this year, despite what some call fragmentation in the form of three separate operating systems on sale in the market. Starting with a U.S. smartphone market share of 14 per cent in January (according to an AC Nielsen report), compared to Apple's 32 per cent and RIM's 34 per cent, Android assimilated a dominating 32 per cent share of the market by August 2010, leaving RIM and Apple each a quarter. The introduction of Froyo (Android 2.2), saw wide-scale manufacturer adoption, and a burgeoning of Android market share.

Now, Gingerbread (Android 2.3) is already being shown off, and the improvements it promises will soon be mass-adopted by manufacturers in early 2011. Android, just like iOS, will soon also get a tablet-oriented variant, called Honeycomb (Android 3.0).

Mobile brands

Nokia remained at the top of the handset market, but lost a chunk of its lead. LG, Sony Ericsson and RIM also suffered major losses, while Apple saw some astounding growth – bagging a top four spot, ahead of RIM and Sony Ericsson! Samsung held on to its fifth spot. HTC and Motorola, although not on the list for now, are also quickly gaining market share, and might pose a serious threat to Apple and RIM in 2011.

At home in India, it's the domestic brands that have made the most impact, taking chunks of market shares away from Nokia and Samsung. We have a really complex market, with about 35 brands competing in a cut-throat business. In India, Nokia's share fell from 54 per cent at the end of June 2009 to 36.3 per cent in June 2010. In contrast, the top four domestic brands (Micromax, Spice, Karbonn and Lava) together account for nearly 33 per cent of the sales. Now Nokia has contested these figures, and these numbers are usually consumed with a pinch of salt, but it's undeniable that the Indian brands are on the rise. The Top 5 according to IDC were Nokia, Samsung, G'Five, LG, and Micromax.



Tablets

With a launch seemingly every other day, 2010 was a joy for tablet lovers. The Apple iPad was the first major device to hit the market in April, and it sold a whopping 3 million units in under three months!

Other tablets were slow to arrive on the scene officially, with the Samsung Galaxy Tab hitting markets only recently, after the Dell Streak launched in June to a lukewarm reception. The Toshiba Folio 100 also launched with poor reviews. The CrunchPad, which later became the JooJoo from Fusion Garage, gave us hope, but it was plagued with usability issues. The Indian favourite, Notion Ink's Adam, is still under development, and is expected to release only in 2011, but it still looks promising.

HP ended-up sticking with webOS 2.0 for its consumer-oriented tablets, and used Windows 7 on its enterprise oriented devices. It's just released the high-performance HP Slate 500 for enterprise customers, which looks to have a promising future.

The Apple iPad has yet to hit Indian markets, officially. The most interesting tablet available here is Olive Telecom's recently

Top 5 mobile phone vendors, Q3 2010 (Units in Millions)

Vendor	Q3 (10) Unit Shipments	Q3 (10) Market Share	Q3 (09) Unit Shipments	Q3 (09) Market Share	Percentage Change
1. Nokia	110.4	32.4 per cent	108.5	36.5 per cent	1.8 per cent
2. Samsung	71.4	21.0 per cent	60.2	20.3 per cent	18.6 per cent
3. LG Electronics	28.4	8.3 per cent	31.6	10.6 per cent	-10.1 per cent
4. Apple	14.1	4.1 per cent	7.4	2.5 per cent	90.5 per cent
5. R.I.M.	12.4	3.6 per cent	8.5	2.9 per cent	45.9 per cent
Others	103.8	30.5 per cent	80.9	27.2 per cent	28.30 per cent
Total	340.5	100 per cent	297.1	100 per cent	14.6 per cent